

*Everything You Wanted to Know
Bad Breath, But Were Afraid to Ask
Alfred Hitchcock Part I*

Sanjeev Khandekar

2008

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Genus Homogenous

Gitanjali Dang

Most creative endeavours wear the nervature of a collage. In his dual role of an artist and a cultural commentator, Sanjeev Khandekar picks red alert crises with tremendous alacrity and efficiently plaits them with memes that enjoy high circulation to phrase a visual argument, which cuts more than just plain ice.

In *Everything You Ever Wanted to Know about Bad Breath but were Afraid to Ask Alfred Hitchcock (Part I)*, Khandekar summons the lugubriously elegant white test tube orchids as his prime suspect. In doing so, he uses the orchids as a catchall motif, which reek of the larger predicaments of environmental depredation and the more specific conundrums posed by genetic modification of organisms. In his new exhibition, he gives the contentious subject matter a thoroughgoing pat down and fuses it with strands of noir cinema to create what in the filmgoer's patois would be termed as the perfect double bill.

The jaunty title calls to mind the tomes we possessed in our youth. It would be a rare event if the bookshelf of an adolescent were not weighed down by at least one book with a title that adhered to the Everything You Ever Wanted to Know about but were Afraid to Ask variety. In its various bookish permutations, the title to this exhibition has entered our vocabulary where it remains inextricably cosseted by our quasi-encyclopaedic aspirations and leanings.

It can't be without significance that the title also references Slavoj Žižek's *Everything You Always Wanted to Know about Lacan: But Were Afraid to Ask Hitchcock*. Khandekar's aesthetic and intellectual temperament has more often than not dovetailed with the delightfully recalcitrant Slovene philosopher's contentious pronouncements. Žižek's engagement with cinema is well known; he articulated the criticality of cinema vis-à-vis his philosophical practice when he scripted and presented director Sophie Fiennes' documentary *The Pervert's Guide to Cinema* (2006).

In this documentary, Žižek analyses films that are after his own heart and he does so from a psychoanalytic perspective. Although Žižek has displayed no prolonged affinity for noir, and Jean-Luc Goddard – another quintessential personage of the Left – has considered noir, and its consequent cortege of emotions, as vulgar; Khandekar does not blinker his narrative with any such biases. In *Everything You Ever Wanted to Know about Bad Breath but were Afraid to Ask Alfred Hitchcock (Part I)*, Khandekar marshals motifs – such as shadows, frosted murkiness, abrupt slashes of red and the like – that are vital to film noir's erudite vocabulary of suspense.

Of the thirteen works that comprise the exhibition, the twelve that vacillate between the photographic and the painterly are each entitled Kludge. The thirteenth work, a marble sculptural installation, goes by the ironic appellation — *Perfect Kludge*. In computing pidgin, kludge is often understood as an acronym for clumsy with a k, lame, ugly, dumb, but a good enough mechanism. A collection of ill-assorted parts — both software and hardware — pulled together to create a make-do whole.

From 1992 to 1995, in his capacity as a columnist for a range of publications, Khandekar commented at length on matters of environment, gardening and landscaping. It was during this period that he first mapped out chinks in the hitherto implacable façade of genetic modification projects and other initiatives that have hotboxed the environment.

When Khandekar was no longer writing columns he veered towards the visual arts, where he presciently assessed, as best he could, imponderables such as environment and biology in the work *Sceptical Environmentalist* (2003) and the series *Bio Music* (2003).

According to one readily accepted nugget of scientific certainty, our visual appetite for beauty is best sated by easily consumable symmetry. But when the heterogeneity of entire ecological units was uprooted in favour of a cloying symmetry, Khandekar was rightly alarmed by the conviction with which he was being spoon-fed - genus homogenous.

Quests embarked on by corporates in the penumbra of exalted ideals are in fact a ploy to landscape the ecosystem and make it more palatable. Documentaries such as Angelo Sacerdote's very powerful *Fed up! Genetic Engineering, Industrial Agriculture and Sustainable Alternatives* (2002) have succinctly established that biotechnology has thus far been incapable of stymieing the epidemics of hunger and malnutrition. But unlike the tireless crusader Vandana Shiva, Khandekar's stand is not constructed entirely of absolutes.

As has always been his wont, Khandekar iterates questions that have been variously articulated in voices that are often made inaudible by propagandist decoy subplots of altruism. However, he is also aware that for the most part, those opposed to genetic modification and other quick fixes are using heuristics to confront the tinny underbelly of late capitalism, which is fraught with patterns of environmental abuse.



Sceptical Environmentalist, 2003
WC on 300 gsm cold pressed WC paper,
30 inch X 22 inch



Bio Music, 2003

WC on 300 gsm cold pressed WC paper.

16 inch X 14 inch

For precisely the same reason, the artist has activated the ambivalence that the term kludge implies. At this juncture, it would interest the viewer/reader to note that kludge bears a sly aural resemblance to the noun 'clues'.

Khandekar's recent suite was mobilised by a work entitled *Bad Breath* (2007). The concluding panel of a triptych, this collaborative project with fellow artist Vaishali Narkar also marked the first time Khandekar called on photography to underscore a predicament. If in *Bad Breath* Khandekar employed the photograph as is, then in the *Kludge* series he treats it with an array of provocative materials. In doing so, Khandekar offsets, as always, the conceptual with a provocative pictorial vocabulary.

These multivalent poetic renderings also possess an oblique revivalistic streak. They call to mind the painted or the embellished black and white photographs, which pre-empted the advent of colour film in mid-20th century India. By amalgamating acrylic, glitter, glass beads and faux diamonds and a slew of other unconventional materials on his photographic prints, the artist formulates a careful rejoinder to the past.

Thus far Khandekar's practice has never been haunted by aesthetic phantoms. Neither is his approach lineal nor is his manner clingy. Not long after he constructs an argument, he pulls it down and reconstitutes it. Keeping in view the larger argument of desires in late capitalist societies, he segues promiscuously from one medium to the next and from one complex articulation to the next in a manner that could easily be read as cavalier. He is both quick and sure-footed.

In the imminent sequel, *Everything You Ever Wanted to Know about Bad Breath but were Afraid to Ask Alfred Hitchcock (Part II)*, Khandekar's protean visual language disallows any and all formulaic dalliances, which would ordinarily have encumbered such projects. From the heavily treated digital prints of Part I, to the life-sized sculptural installations of refrigerators that comprise Part II, the motif may have undergone a radical transmogrification but the narrative and the antagonist remain unmoved.



Bad Breath, 2007

Sanjeev Khandekar & Vaishali Narkar

Inkjet print on archival paper,

48 inches X 30 inch

Be it the attention-seeking test-tube orchids preening for the flashbulbs in Part I, or the mouth-wateringly crammed and obscenely insatiable refrigerators of Part II, the unmitigated advance of global consumerism has been debilitating. By extension, the environment has been carpet bombed by canned, test-tubed, pre-cut and genetically modified goods that cater to well-heeled taste buds. These thrill-seeking knobs of flesh throb when confronted by the glibly attractive fronts of nifty double-doored refrigerators. In turn, the refrigerator transforms into an ethically questionable ecosystem, which is out to titillate the consumer's new underbelly of desires. In doing so the motif also stands in opposition to a natural order, which is now regarded anachronistic by those enamoured of biotechnology's plethora of promises.

In *Everything You Ever Wanted to Know about Bad Breath but were Afraid to Ask Alfred Hitchcock (Part I)*, the images are variously complicated by either the molecular structures of Valium and Prozac or a smattering Durex's cherry flavoured lubricant that is slathered on certain other prints. In doing so the artist productively lassoes in his past preoccupations wherein he interrogated the validity of constantly ferreting for new highs.

It was in *Kegel Exercise: Aswani Mudra* (2007) that Khandekar first manipulated marble with pietre dure work to phrase a subtext of desires. In the *Perfect Kludge*, he returns to Makrana marble but not without creating legroom for departure. In the work, Khandekar quotes the visuality of a Shell advertisement, thereby questioning the integrity of its tagline, "Chemistry plus creative thinking equals clean city air." The mother-of-pearl inlay that generates a haze of noir shadows is a response to the high relief test tube orchids. By facilitating marble's collusion with the high stakes sphere of genetic modification the artist enriches his concerns with conceptual complexities.

Once the test tube orchids – hanging low like nervy stalactites in chic hotel and offices – transfixed Khandekar, there was an onrush of perspective. In the upper echelons of

pornography, plenty rides on what is unambiguously referred to as the cumshot or the money shot. Deliberately flattened out by the flash of the artist's camera, these orchids quickly become symptomatic of the games being fleshed out in the brutal Colosseum of desire. Companies such as the US-anchored Monsanto—a leading chemical company, which also furnishes the seed technology for 90 per cent of the world's genetically engineered crops—hope to suck the environment dry of its vital marrow just so they can either pander to ever-growing desires or invent desires where there are none.

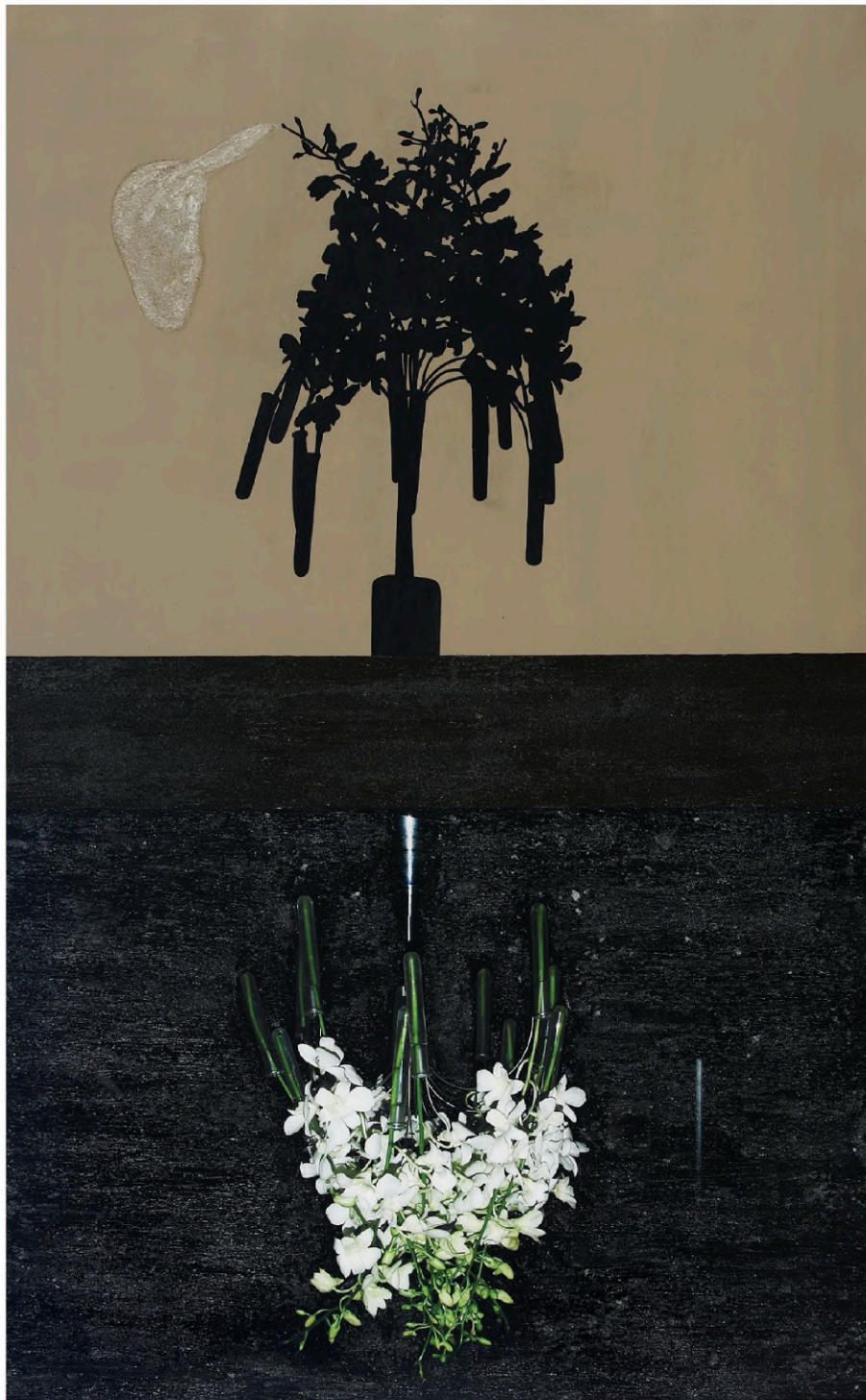
Earlier this year, Manoj Night Shyamalan – another man enamoured of Alfred Hitchcock – in his roundly trashed *The Happening* amplified nature's fury. In the film, nature counterattacks predatorial human beings with a ragbag of toxins and compels them to commit suicide. The film could be read as the radical suggestion of an environmentalist who fears that nature will attempt to restore its equilibrium by getting back at the *Homo sapiens sapiens*. Although Khandekar does not fear any such needlessly melodramatic apocalyptic fictions, he can't help but think of nature's inflated roster of complaints.

The display strategy, with its suspenseful light design and doomy black 'n' blue wall paint, adds to the dark momentum but the telltale syntax of noir is the red herring in this noir-to-the-bones setup. The crime/focal point lies elsewhere. And although the approach road and the accompanying signage vary vastly, Khandekar is still preoccupied with the same dilemmas.

In *Everything You Ever Wanted to Know about Bad Breath but were Afraid to Ask Alfred Hitchcock (Part I)*, the artist coalesces clues around his well-founded concerns. And as in the case of the classic noir, he suspects that the *dénouement* to this thickening plot will be unhappy.

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© Gitanjali Dang is an independent curator and critic. From 2005–08 she was art critic at The Hindustan Times, and currently contributes to publications such as Art India, The Economic Times and Mid-Day.



Title: Kludge

Medium: Acrylic, gloss, glitter, glass beads, chemical, Phosphorescent Green, extra solid gloss gel, gold mica flakes, GAC200 acrylic polymer, varnish & inkjet on Archies archival paper, Day View

Size: 48" X 30"

Year: 2008



Title: Kludge
Medium: Acrylic, gloss, glitter, glass beads, chemical,
extra solid gloss gel, gold mica flakes, GAC200 acrylic polymer,
varnish & inkjet on Archies archival paper.
Size: 48" X 30"
Year: 2008



Title: "Perfect Kludge"

Medium: Makrana Marble, Mother of Pearls, Aluminium, Polymer Acrylic Chemical, Electroplating on Fibre, varnish, glass beads, glass, glitter, and drinking water with pale yellow shadow on marble.

Size: 60" x 36" x 84

Year: 2008